

Habitat & Cultivation Castor oil plant is probably native to eastern Africa. It is cultivated in hot climates around the world. The seed capsules are gathered throughout the year when nearly ripe and are then put out in the sun to mature.

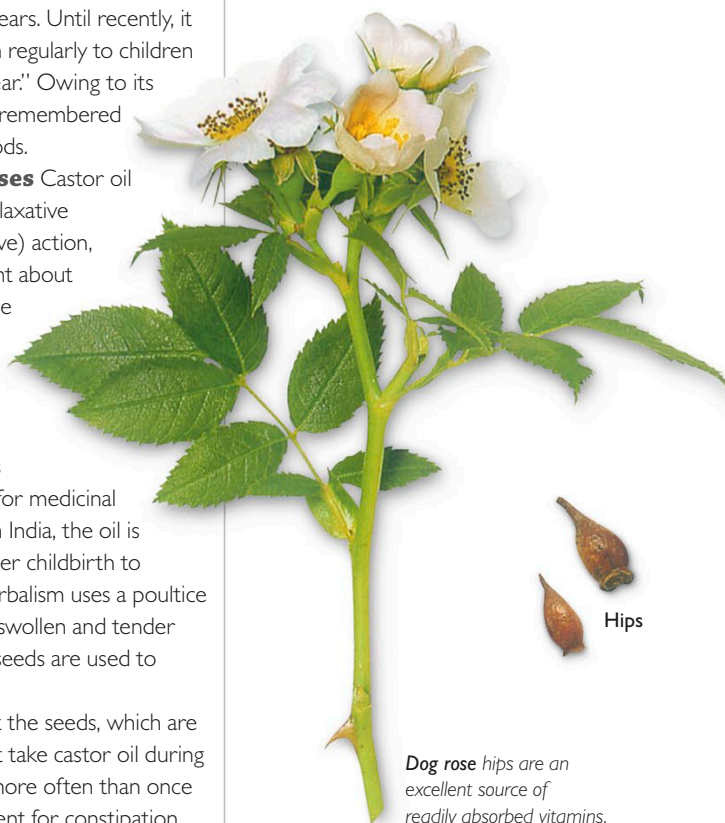
Parts Used Seed oil, seeds.

Constituents The seeds contain 45–55% fixed oil, which consists mainly of glycerides of ricinoleic acid, ricin (a highly toxic protein), ricinine (an alkaloid), and lectins. The seeds are highly poisonous—2 are sufficient to kill an adult—but the toxins do not pass into the expressed oil.

History & Folklore Castor oil has been used medicinally for about 4,000 years. Until recently, it was a common remedy given regularly to children “to help keep the system clear.” Owing to its unpleasant taste, castor oil is remembered as the bane of many childhoods.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Castor oil is well known for its strongly laxative (and, in higher doses, purgative) action, prompting a bowel movement about 3–5 hours after ingestion. The oil is so effective that it is regularly used to clear the digestive tract in cases of poisoning. Castor oil is well tolerated by the skin, and it is sometimes used as a vehicle for medicinal and cosmetic preparations. In India, the oil is massaged into the breasts after childbirth to stimulate milk flow. Indian herbalism uses a poultice of castor oil seeds to relieve swollen and tender joints. In China, the crushed seeds are used to treat facial palsy.

Cautions Do not ingest the seeds, which are extremely poisonous. Do not take castor oil during pregnancy, and do not take more often than once every few weeks as a treatment for constipation.



Dog rose hips are an excellent source of readily absorbed vitamins.

Rosa canina (Rosaceae)

Dog Rose

Description Climbing perennial growing to a height of 10 ft (3 m). Has curved thorns, leaves with 2–3 pairs of toothed leaflets, pink or white flowers, and scarlet fruit (called “hips”).

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, temperate areas of Asia, and North Africa, dog rose grows in hedgerows and thickets and in open areas. The fruit is picked in autumn.

Part Used Hips.

Constituents Dog rose hips contain vitamins C (up to 1.25%), A, B₁, B₂, B₃, and K, flavonoids, tannins (2–3%), invert sugar, pectin, plant acids, polyphenols, carotenoids, volatile oil, and vanillin.

History & Folklore The hips of the dog rose were a popular sweetmeat in the Middle Ages.

The plants were not esteemed to the same degree as were cultivated roses (*R. gallica*, following entry), but dog rose was valued as the source of a widely used folk remedy for chest problems.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Dog rose hips have extremely high levels of vitamins. When consumed fresh, they provide vitamins and other nutrients in a form that is readily absorbed by the body. This makes rose-hip syrup a nourishing drink for young children. The tannin content of rose hips makes them a gentle remedy for diarrhea. The hips are mildly diuretic.

Research Clinical studies investigating the use of rose-hip extracts for osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis, and lower back pain have produced mixed results. Some have shown positive benefits, others none. It is likely that some people will benefit more than others, and given that rose-hip extracts are very safe, rose hips and rose-hip extract are well worth trying for arthritic conditions.

Rosa gallica (Rosaceae)

Rose

Description Deciduous shrub growing to about 5 ft (1.5 m). Has a smooth stem, sharp thorns, serrated leaves with 2–3 pairs of leaflets, semi-double deep pink or red flowers, and scarlet hips.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Middle East, the rose is not now found in the wild except

as a garden escape. It has been cultivated for at least 3,000 years. The flowers are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Flowers, essential oil.

Constituents Rose contains a volatile oil consisting of geraniol, nerol, citronellol, geranic acid and other terpenes, and many other substances.

History & Folklore The rose comes originally from Iran and has been cultivated there since antiquity. Sappho, the 6th-century BCE Greek poet, described the red rose as the “Queen of flowers.” In Rome, it was much used in festivities and the petals were consumed as food. Rosewater was prepared by the Arab physician Avicenna (980–1037 CE). During the Middle Ages and the Renaissance, the rose was esteemed as a remedy for depression.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The rose is currently little used in herbal medicine, but it is probably time for a reevaluation of its medicinal benefits. The essential oil, called “attar of rose,” is used in aromatherapy as a mildly sedative, antidepressant, and anti-inflammatory remedy. Rose petals and their preparations have a similar action. They also reduce high cholesterol levels. Rosewater is mildly astringent and makes a valuable lotion for inflamed and sore eyes.

Caution Do not take the essential oil internally without professional supervision.

Rubia tinctorum (Rubiaceae)

Madder

Description Evergreen perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has whorls of finely toothed lance-shaped leaves, greenish-white flowers, and black berries containing 2 seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Madder is native to southern Europe, western Asia, and North Africa. It flourishes in open areas and on roadsides, and amid rubble. The root is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Madder contains anthraquinone derivatives (including ruberythric acid, alizarin, and purpurin), an iridoid (asperuloside), resin, and calcium.

History & Folklore Throughout history, madder has been used principally as a red dye for a variety of fabrics. In the ancient world, madder root was taken medicinally to treat jaundice, sciatica, and paralysis, and it was also used as a diuretic. When ingested, madder imparts its distinctive color to bones, milk, and urine, and it probably owed much of its reputation as a diuretic to this property.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Madder fell largely out of use in the 19th century, and is now only rarely employed to treat kidney and bladder stones.